Arab Open University
FACULTY OF LANGUAGE STUDIES

A112T
Cultures
Main – All Branches
Midterm Exam

2025-2026/Second Semester
Date:14 April 2026
2:30 – 4:30

Number of Exam Pages: 3 (including this cover sheet)	**Time Allowed: 2 Hours**

INSTRUCTIONS

This Exam consists of TWO PARTS.

Part 1 contains 3 Short Answer Questions. You must choose TWO and fully answer them PARAGRAPH FORMAT.

Part 2 contains 2 Essay Questions. You must choose ONE of them and fully answer it in ESSAY FORMAT.

Write the question number next to each answer.

Do not answer more questions than required.

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Part 1: Short Answer Questions

(10 points = 5 points for each answer)

Please choose TWO of the following questions and respond to them in paragr format. Each answer should be approximately 80 words long, addressing all rele aspects of the question with appropriate evidence from the course material. En that each paragraph includes a clear topic sentence, supporting details, an conclusion.

1. Who were the **people** commonly found in the **Athenian Agora**, and what was its **role** in Athenian society?
2. What roles did **metics** play in Athenian society, and how were they viewed by Athenian citizens?
3. What were the **main types of events** held in the **Colosseum**, and why were they popular?

Part 2: Essay Questions

(20 points)

Please choose ONE of the essay prompts below and write a comprehensive response in essay format. Your essay should be around 350 words, covering all relevant aspects of t question and backed by evidence from the course material. Make sure to structure your essay with an introduction, multiple body paragraphs, and a conclusion.

4. How did the institutions of **Athenian democracy** — the **Ekklesia** (Assembly), **Boule** (Council of 500), and **Archons** (chief magistrates) — function, and what were the key limitations that made this democracy exclusive and unequal?

   Sub-Questions (20 marks total — 4 marks each)

   a. **Introduction (4 marks)** Introduce Athenian democracy as a pioneering but exclusive system and briefly explain how its key institutions — the Ekklesia, Boule, and Archor — shared political power among male citizens.

   b. **Body Paragraph 1 – The Ekklesia and Boule (4 marks)** Explain the roles of the Assembly and the Council of 500 in Athenian direct democracy, and discuss how they enabled citizen participation in law-making and governance.

   c. **Body Paragraph 2 – The Archons (4 marks)** Discuss the role of the Archons in Athenian political life and explain how their authority fitted within the broader democratic system.

   d. **Body Paragraph 3 – Limitations of Athenian Democracy (4 marks)** Explain how Athenian democracy excluded women, slaves, and metics from political participation, and discuss how this dependence on slavery and exclusion undermined its democratic ideals.

   e. **Conclusion (4 marks)** Explain how Athenian democracy was both radical for its time and deeply unequal, and what its limitations reveal about the relationship between political freedom and social exclusion.

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5. Explain how **Nero** used the **Domus Aurea** to show his power as the last emperor of the Julio-Claudian Dynasty and why this made Roman people angry with him.

Sub-Questions (20 marks total — 4 marks each)

a. **Introduction (4 marks)** What was the Julio-Claudian Dynasty, and why was Nero's position as the last emperor of this family important to Rome?

b. **Body Paragraph 1 (4 marks)** Describe what the Domus Aurea was and what it looked like, using details from the remains and artwork that archaeologists have found.

c. **Body Paragraph 2 (4 marks)** According to Pliny's description, what special features and luxuries did the Domus Aurea have, and what do these tell us about how Nero wanted to be seen as emperor?

d. **Body Paragraph 3 (4 marks)** Why did Roman people become angry and upset about the Domus Aurea, and how does this show that Nero used architecture as a way to display his political power?

e. **Conclusion (4 marks)** What was the legacy of Nero and the Domus Aurea, and what does this teach us about how Roman emperors used buildings to show power in their capital city?

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End of the Exam!

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